Handova

An initiative of **Ethical Bridge**

TRUST & SAFETY · POLICY AND PROCEDURE

Whistleblowing Policy and Procedure

How anyone can raise a concern about wrongdoing safely, and how we protect them.

Version 1.0 | Approved 20 October 2026
Handova, an initiative of Ethical Bridge LLC

Skills handed over.
Capability that stays.

DOCUMENT CONTROL

About this document

DOCUMENT	Handova Whistleblowing Policy and Procedure
TYPE	Policy and procedure
OWNER	Julieta Castiñeira de Dios
APPROVED BY	Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, founder, for Ethical Bridge LLC
VERSION	1.0
DATE OF APPROVAL	20 October 2026
NEXT REVIEW	October 2027, or sooner when Handova has a team, after a serious incident or when the law changes
APPLIES TO	Anyone: the Handova team, volunteers, professionals, organisations and members of the public
OPERATOR	Handova is an initiative of Ethical Bridge LLC, registered in Wyoming, USA
CONTACT	safeguarding@handova.org · hello@handova.org
LANGUAGE	English

CONTENTS

01 Our commitment
02 What you can raise
03 Protection from retaliation
04 Confidentiality and anonymity
05 How to raise a concern
06 When the concern is about the founder
07 What happens next
08 Raising concerns outside Handova
09 Support
10 Records and data protection
11 Oversight and review

PROPORTIONATE TO OUR SIZE

Handova is in its early stage. Today one person, the founder, runs both Handova and Ethical Bridge. This is our **first version**: it sets out what we do now and who does it. We will expand it as Handova grows and builds a team with dedicated safeguarding and compliance roles. Until then:

- **Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, the founder, is the safeguarding lead.** She receives reports, decides on protective action and keeps the records described here.
- **An independent contact** handles any concern about the founder, or that the founder is involved in, and covers urgent cases when the founder can't be reached for more than 48 hours. This is a trusted person outside Handova and Ethical Bridge: **to be confirmed soon**. They don't run Handova or investigate alone: they receive the concern, make sure it is handled fairly and get outside advice when needed.
- **We review this policy** at least once a year, as soon as Handova has a team, and after any serious incident.

AT A GLANCE

- If you reasonably believe something is wrong at Handova, tell us. You do not need proof, and your motive does not matter.
- Anyone can raise a concern: the Handova team, volunteers helping Handova, professionals, organisations and members of the public.
- You can raise it confidentially or anonymously.
- If your concern is about the founder, it goes to the independent contact, not to her.
- Reports made on the platform get an automatic acknowledgement with a reference. Emailed concerns are acknowledged within 2 working days, the same day if someone may be at risk. You get feedback within 3 months.
- We do not tolerate retaliation against anyone who speaks up or helps.

WHO THIS APPLIES TO

This policy covers concerns raised by, and protects:

- **the Handova team:** today the founder, and in future anyone with admin access, anyone who reviews profiles, organisations or needs, and contractors, including former team members and people applying to join;
- **volunteers helping Handova itself**, and Ethical Bridge LLC people when they act for Handova;
- **professionals and organisations** using Handova, including an organisation's members and safeguarding focal points;
- **anyone else**, including people an organisation serves and members of the public.

It also protects people who help a reporter, and people close to them who could be affected.

Legal protection for whistleblowers depends on where you are and your relationship with Handova; this policy protects you on Handova regardless.

PART A

Policy

SECTION 01

Our commitment

Handova depends on trust. People can only rely on us if problems are found and fixed early, including problems with how Handova itself is run. We commit to:

- clear, confidential channels, including an anonymous one and one that does not go to the founder;
- following up every concern fairly and on time;
- protecting the identity of reporters and of the people named;
- acting on any retaliation;
- learning from every concern.

Ethical Bridge LLC is registered in Wyoming, USA, and is subject to US federal and Wyoming law. People take part from many countries, so we also follow the law that applies where they are, including the EU and UK GDPR for personal data. Where rules differ, we follow the one that gives people more protection. We also follow international good practice on whistleblowing, whatever the legal minimum.

SECTION 02

What you can raise

You can raise any wrongdoing connected to Handova that has happened, is happening or is likely to happen, for example:

- a crime, such as fraud, bribery, theft or identity fraud;
- a breach of a legal duty, including data protection law;
- a danger to someone's health, safety or wellbeing;
- a safeguarding concern that is being ignored, mishandled or covered up;
- misuse of Handova's or Ethical Bridge's funds, grants or resources;
- misleading funders, organisations or the public, for example by inflating impact figures or misstating how Handova checks people;
- a hidden data breach, or someone reading conversations or data they should not;
- approval, verification or report decisions influenced by money, favours or personal links;
- discrimination, or a serious breach of the Handova agreements or policies;
- retaliation against someone who raised a concern;
- any attempt to hide any of the above.

Reasonable belief, not proof

You need a reasonable belief that what you report shows wrongdoing. You are protected even if you turn out to be mistaken. Your reasons for reporting do not matter. Knowingly making a false report is a breach of the Handova agreements.

Other routes

- **Safeguarding, sexual exploitation and abuse, fraud and harassment** on the platform go through **Report a concern** and the matching procedures. If you raise them here, you are still protected and we pass them on straight away.
- **A disagreement about a contribution**, such as scope or quality, is best solved in Messages or by ending the contribution.
- **A decision about your own account**, such as a removal, can be reviewed if you ask within 30 days. Where Handova restricts or removes an account or content, we tell the person why and how to ask for a review.

If you are unsure, raise it anyway. We will tell you which route applies.

SECTION 03

Protection from retaliation

Retaliation means treating you worse because you raised a concern or helped with one. On Handova this could include:

- suspending, hiding or closing your profile or organisation;
- withholding hour approvals or an endorsement, or removing impact CV entries;
- a negative "would you work together again" answer;
- ending a contribution, declining your applications or excluding you from future needs;
- harassment, threats or pressure in Messages or elsewhere;
- revealing your identity or damaging your reputation;
- ending a team or volunteer role.

Anyone who retaliates, or threatens to, faces removal from Handova or the end of their role. If something harmful happens to you after you raise a concern, we will treat it as retaliation unless the person responsible shows a separate, legitimate reason. We will reverse its effects where we can, for example by restoring a profile or record. Legal remedies depend on where you are; this policy protects you on Handova regardless.

SECTION 04

Confidentiality and anonymity

- We share your identity, or anything that could identify you, only with people who need it to handle your concern, unless you give explicit consent. If the law requires disclosure, we tell you first, unless that would harm an investigation or legal proceedings.
- We also protect the identity of people named in a concern.
- You can report anonymously by writing from an email address that does not identify you. This lets us reply. We follow up anonymous concerns as far as we can, but may be limited if we cannot ask questions.

PART B

Procedure

Today one person, Julieta Castiñeira de Dios, handles every concern, unless it is about her or she is involved, in which case the independent contact handles it. We will expand this procedure as Handova grows.

SECTION 05

How to raise a concern

CHANNEL	USE IT FOR	DETAILS
Email the safeguarding lead (Julieta Castiñeira de Dios)	Most concerns	safeguarding@handova.org

CHANNEL	USE IT FOR	DETAILS
Independent contact	Concerns about the founder, or anything she is involved in	**to be confirmed soon**
Report a concern	Concerns about a profile, need, conversation or contribution	On the platform (signed-in users)
Anonymous	Any concern	An email to either address above, from an address that does not identify you
Video call	If you prefer to talk	Ask through any channel; arranged within 7 days

You can write in English, Spanish, Portuguese or French. We use translation tools where needed, with care for confidentiality. If you talk to us, we write it up and offer you the chance to check it.

Tell us what happened, when, who was involved, how you know, and whether you have reported it elsewhere. Share evidence you already have, but do not investigate yourself or break any rules to get more.

SECTION 06

When the concern is about the founder

The founder is Handova's only administrator and its safeguarding lead, and she can see every report made on the platform. So concerns about her, or anything she is involved in, go directly to the independent contact (**to be confirmed soon**), by email, not through Handova's systems. The independent contact:

- assesses the concern, decides the next steps and gives feedback to the reporter;
- can ask for any records needed, and the founder must provide them without delay;
- keeps these case records separately from Handova's systems.

For serious or complex cases, Handova may bring in an external adviser or investigator. The founder does not see these case records and takes no part in the decision. The same route applies to the founder's conflicts of interest and to reviews of her decisions.

SECTION 07

What happens next

Julieta Castiñeira de Dios (or the independent contact, for concerns about her):

1. **Acknowledges** the concern, with a reference, next steps and your protections. Platform reports are acknowledged automatically; emails within 2 working days, the same day if someone may be at risk.
2. **Protects** people and evidence straight away if needed, for example by suspending an account or freezing a conversation.

3. **Assesses** within 14 days whether it is wrongdoing, whether more information is needed, and which Handova procedure applies (Fraud, Bribery and Corruption; Safeguarding; or Anti-Harassment).
4. **Looks into it** in proportion to the issue. People named are treated fairly, told of the allegation when this will not put evidence or anyone at risk, and given the chance to respond. She decides on the balance of probabilities and records her reasons.
5. **Reports to authorities** where the law requires it, or where someone is in immediate danger.
6. **Gives you feedback** within 3 months of acknowledgement on what has been done or is planned, and why, as far as confidentiality allows, then every 3 months until the case is closed.
7. **Closes the case**, tells you the outcome where appropriate, and records lessons.

If we find no wrongdoing, or the concern belongs to another process, we tell you our decision and reasons in writing. We will expand this procedure as Handova grows.

SECTION 08

Raising concerns outside Handova

We encourage you to come to us first so we can act quickly, but you do not have to. You can also go to:

- a regulator or public authority responsible for the issue, such as a data protection authority for a data breach;
- the police, especially if someone is in danger or a crime has been committed;
- a lawyer, for advice.

Going public, for example to the media, is protected only in limited circumstances, which vary by country. If someone is in immediate danger, contact local emergency services first.

SECTION 09

Support

Julieta Castiñeira de Dios (or the independent contact) keeps you updated and agrees practical steps with you to prevent retaliation, such as pausing a contribution, freezing a conversation or suspending an account.

SECTION 10

Records and data protection

- The person handling the concern keeps a secure register: reference, date received, acknowledgement, assessment, actions, feedback given and outcome. Anonymous concerns are recorded too.
- Only the safeguarding lead can see case records, and only the independent contact can see records of cases about the founder.

- We keep case records for 6 years after the case closes, or longer if legal proceedings are ongoing or expected. Cases involving a child are kept until the child turns 25 or for 6 years after closure, whichever is later. Then they are deleted. We review records once a year and delete personal data that is not relevant straight away.
- Personal data is handled under the Handova Data Protection Policy and privacy notice. Some data rights may be limited to protect a reporter's identity or an investigation, where the law allows.

SECTION 11

Oversight and review

Each year Julieta Castiñeira de Dios writes a short anonymised summary of concerns, outcomes, timelines and lessons, kept on file and shared with the independent contact once named. She reviews this policy every year.

Related: Handova Safeguarding Policy and Procedure; Anti-Harassment, Intimidation and Bullying Policy and Procedure; Code of Conduct; Data Protection Policy; Fraud, Bribery and Corruption Policy and Procedure; Independent Contact Role Note; professional, organisation and contribution agreements; terms of use; privacy notice.